

The International Space Station

The International Space Station (ISS) is a modular space station in low Earth orbit. It was launched in 1998 as a joint project between five space agencies: NASA, Roscosmos, JAXA, ESA, and CSA.

The ISS orbits the Earth at an average altitude of about 400 kilometers, traveling at approximately 28,000 kilometers per hour. At this speed it completes one orbit roughly every 90 minutes, so the crew experiences 16 sunrises and sunsets every day.

The station is about the size of a football field and has been continuously occupied since November 2000. Astronauts typically stay for missions of about six months, conducting research in microgravity, biology, and materials science.

Because there is no gravity pulling on their spines, astronauts on the ISS temporarily grow up to five centimeters taller. They must exercise about two hours every day to prevent muscle and bone loss.